This was a life-transforming experience. I loved so many of the places we visited. Each one threw up new questions. When we returned to the US, they stayed with me, leading me to deeper reading and reflection, revealing both new continuities and dead ends between India's past and its contemporary society. I wrote short essays on some of these places. Slowly, a more coherent idea of India's civilizational trajectory began to take shape in my mind, anchored around my earthy and often romantic encounters with some of its most thrilling sites and monuments.

At the same time, I noticed how interest in the past was surging in India. Modernity, capitalism and nationalism were fuelling in us Indians a desire to understand our place in the world in new ways. More than ever before, we now visited historical sites and hungered for new narratives about them: What had happened here? Why did it end? Too often, sadly, the popular new narratives are dull, untrue, or driven by chauvinism—instead of scholarly rigour and a humanistic temper, where openness, evidence and empathy lead the way. And how we see our past is increasingly shaping our idea of India and where we want to go as a society.

In 2013, my partner and I permanently quit our professions and relocated to India for the long term. After completing a book of essays and a novel, I returned my attention to the places that had captivated me in those previous two years of travel—the lost and found worlds of ancient and medieval India. I now decided to write about their remarkable stories at length.

I looked for sites that spanned north and south, and a wide swathe of time. I settled on six. It's hard to say why I chose these specific sites and not others. It was partly my idiosyncratic desire to understand these six lost worlds better. Each represented a distinct past in a land of many pasts. I saw them as the keys to a deeper understanding of Indians. Each promised a good journey too—a realm of mysteries and rewards that are hard to spell out.

I began planning a book that combined archaeological travel writing with narrative history. I hoped to find the essence of each site's inhabitants—their defining beliefs, customs and institutions; their struggles and living conditions—and their legacy in the cultural mosaic of India. I would lean on both diverse scholarship and primary sources, such as archaeologists' reports as well as the accounts of famous past travellers, many of whom had visited this distinctive land beyond the river Sindhu (Sanskrit for Indus)—a